

Localize a Campaign Before You Launch It in a New Market

Objective

You finish with a one-page pre-flight for each new market: what your team has not done there before, who the audience is this month, which channels and formats fit the language, how the local press is structured, whether the site is technically ready for the market, and one goal with the metrics each local team will see.

"I think the biggest pitfall is thinking, I've done this before, so I'll just do it the way I've always done it, and not digging into the market."
- Laura Smith, ICS-digital

Key Steps

1. **List what you have not done in this market, before the brief is signed.** Mark every market where your team has not run this exact kind of work, and tell the client you need time to check before you commit.
2. **Re-run audience research for this brief and this month.** Don't carry the last market's persona over. Research which channels this audience uses and how it reacts to advertising, for this brief and this month (Laura's team uses GWI).
3. **Profile sub-audiences apart from the country average.** Research expat or diaspora targets on their own. UK nationals in Paris are not the French average.
4. **Have a native speaker check the channels and formats.** Ask someone who knows the language inside out whether each channel and format works there. German words ran past Twitter's character limit.
5. **Map the local media before you design the story.** Find out how the market's press is structured before you build the data story. A UK city split works; slicing the same data by US state does not make it local news.
6. **Check the site is technically ready for the market.** Confirm hreflang is present and correct: every version lists itself and all alternates, links are reciprocal, ISO 639-1 language (+ optional ISO 3166-1 region) codes, an x-default (Google's localized-versions docs). (*inferred*)
7. **Set one goal, then pick the metrics each market reports.** Keep one overall goal in every market; choose the indicative metrics per market and decide which numbers each local team sees.
8. **Front-load the stakeholder map in months one to six.** At kickoff, find where the red tape sits, bring the client's internal experts in, and keep checking over months one to six that data reaches the right people.

Cautionary Notes

- Translation is the input, not the finish.
- Present is not the same as correct.
- Do not slice home-market data by region and call it local.
- Do not chase a hack for AI answers.
- Be careful with memes in a market you do not know.
- This is practitioner advice, not a measured result.

Tips for Efficiency

- Run steps 1 to 5 before the budget is split by market.
- Keep the "not done here before" list from step 1 in the kickoff deck.
- Give the native-speaker check a fixed short brief.
- Reuse the goal, not the metrics.
- Plan for being remembered as well as found.
- Bring digital PR in early.

Source: Laura Smith, Head of Client Strategy, ICS-digital, on Unscripted SEO (recorded Sept 23, 2026). White paper: *The Human-Machine Memory Gap* - distinctivenessintelligence.ics-digital.com. Hreflang reference: developers.google.com/search/docs/specialty/international/localized-versions
Full SOP: seoarcade.com/seo-sop-localize-a-campaign-for-a-new-market/ · Interview recap: seoarcade.com/international-seo-new-market-checks/